

S&P Global France Services PMI®

French services activity rebounds in September

September 2026

First rise in services output since last December

New business falls marginally

Prices charged increase at sharpest rate for more than three years as cost pressures intensify

September PMI® survey data signalled the first rise in business activity across France's service sector in the year-to-date, although demand weakened further and employment levels were reduced again. Meanwhile, prices charged rose considerably, with inflation its fastest in more than three years.

The headline S&P Global France Services PMI Business Activity Index is a gauge of output versus the month prior. A reading above 50.0 signals an increase in business activity compared to the previous month, and the further above 50.0, the faster the expansion signalled.

Rising from 48.0 in August to 51.2 in September, the headline index posted in expansion territory for the first time since last December. The rate of growth signalled was modest, however, and well below the survey average.

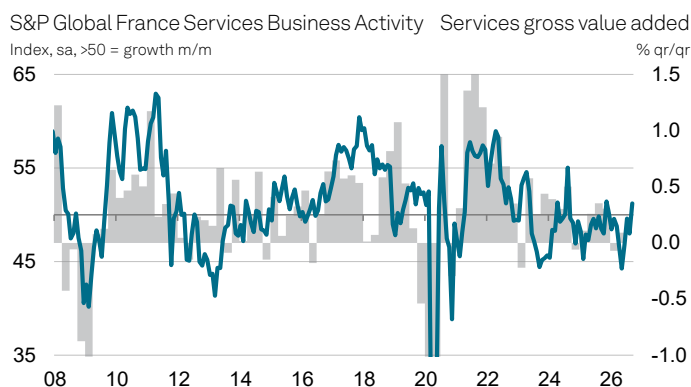
Activity levels were boosted by greater client numbers, according to some panel members. Indeed, there was some evidence of underlying demand conditions picking up, with the index for new business moving closer to the neutral level. That said, the latest data point was indicative of a marginal decrease in new orders overall. Uncertainty was a drag on sales performances, anecdotal evidence suggested.

Securing business from non-domestic customers remained a challenge in September, with new export orders decreasing for a fourteenth month in a row. That said, the pace of decline slowed and was the weakest since November last year.

French services companies lowered employment further at the end of the third quarter, extending the current sequence of job cuts to five months. According to some firms, workforces were trimmed due to restructures. That said, with other businesses recruiting additional staff, the overall rate of decline in job numbers was only marginal and the slowest since June.

Meanwhile, capacity pressures emerged in September, with backlogs of work ticking up on the month.

As for prices, the latest survey data pointed to stronger cost pressures. Higher prices paid for fuel, computer hardware and raw materials were mentioned in firms' anecdotal



Comment

Joe Hayes, Senior Principal Economist at S&P Global Market Intelligence:

"It would be amiss to not question the durability of France's economic expansion in September, given the survey data suggest that underlying demand conditions remain frail. There could be some payback in these numbers after the hit to business activity in August due to extreme heat.

"Nonetheless, faster price increases by firms point to some confidence in pricing power. With the war in the Middle East continuing and global oil and gas prices staying elevated, the risk that energy cost inflation passes through to more parts of the economy is rising."

replies. That said, the rate of inflation was below May's recent high.

To offset margin erosion, French services companies raised their prices charged in September. In fact, the extent to which charges increased was the fastest in more than three years. Some panel members expressed confidence in their pricing power, whereas others made adjustments due to greater cost burdens.

Finally, business expectations were positive, albeit only slightly, as the level of optimism weakened since August. Overall, firms were their least upbeat towards the year-ahead outlook since May. The forthcoming election period, higher interest rates and low client confidence were cited as factors.

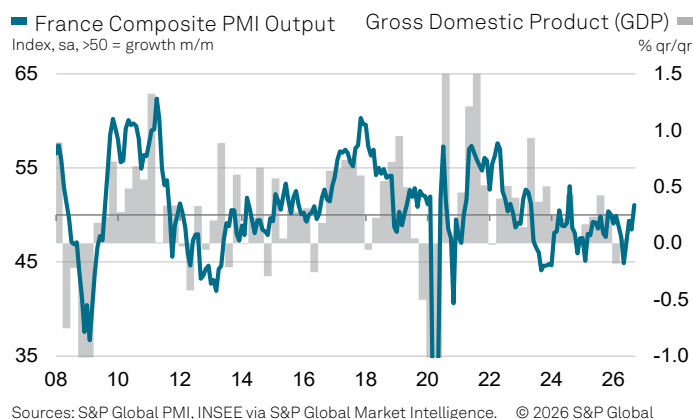
S&P Global France Composite PMI®

The S&P Global France Composite PMI Output Index* rose to a 25-month high of 51.1 in September, from 48.5 in August, taking it above the 50.0 no-change level to signal renewed growth in private sector business activity.

Higher output was attained in the absence of sales and employment growth. New business and workforce numbers both decreased marginally in September.

Expectations meanwhile softened, reflecting weaker sentiment in the service sector.

As for prices, latest survey data signalled a steep acceleration of inflation.



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Methodology

The S&P Global France Services PMI® is compiled by S&P Global from responses to questionnaires sent to a panel of around 400 service sector companies.

The sectors covered include consumer (excluding retail), transport, information, communication, finance, insurance, real estate and business services. The panel is stratified by detailed sector and company workforce size, based on contributions to GDP. Data collection began in May 1998.

Survey responses are collected in the second half of each month and indicate the direction of change compared to the previous month. A diffusion index is calculated for each survey variable. The index is the sum of the percentage of 'higher' responses and half the percentage of 'unchanged' responses. The indices vary between 0 and 100, with a reading above 50 indicating an overall increase compared to the previous month, and below 50 an overall decrease. The indices are then seasonally adjusted.

The headline figure is the Services Business Activity Index. This is a diffusion index calculated from a question that asks for changes in the volume of business activity compared with one month previously. The Services Business Activity Index is comparable to the Manufacturing Output Index. It may be referred to as the 'Services PMI' but is not comparable with the headline manufacturing PMI figure.

The Composite Output Index is a weighted average of the Manufacturing Output Index and the Services Business Activity Index. The weights reflect the relative size of the manufacturing and service sectors according to official GDP data. The Composite Output Index may be referred to as the 'Composite PMI' but is not comparable with the headline manufacturing PMI figure.

Underlying survey data are not revised after publication, but seasonal adjustment factors may be revised from time to time as appropriate which will affect the seasonally adjusted data series.

For further information on the PMI survey methodology, please contact economics@spglobal.com.

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